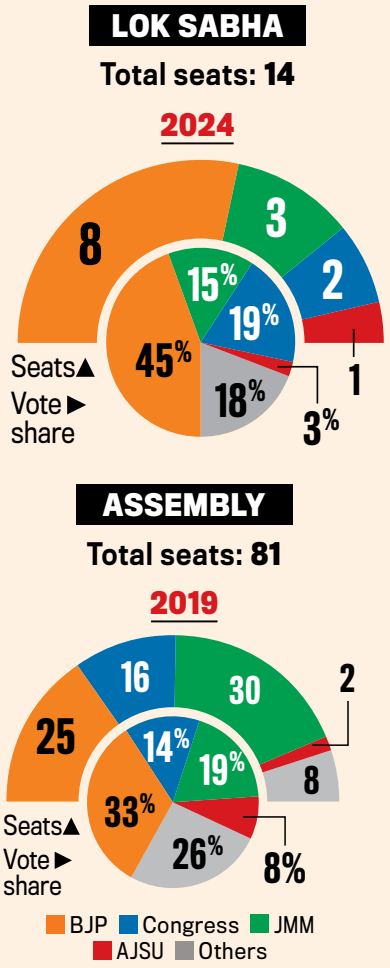
ASSEMBLY POLLS 2024
JHARKHAND

THE BIG FIGHT FOR LEGACY

THE STAGE IS SET FOR A HIGH-STAKES SHOWDOWN AS POLITICAL BIGWIGS AND PARIVARS VIE FOR CONTROL OF THE TRIBAL HEARTLAND

By Amitabh Srivastava



Poll Schedule

First phase: Nov. 13
Second phase: Nov. 20
Counting: Nov. 23

Seat Distribution

NDA	I.N.D.I.A.
BJP 68	JMM 43
AJSU 10	Congress 30
JD(U) 2	RJD 7
LJP (Ram Vilas) 1	CPI(M-L) 4
	(INDIA bloc is effectively united in 78 seats)

Graphic by TANMOY CHAKRABORTY

As the air turned crisp in Hata village, East Singhbhum, a crowd sitting on red plastic chairs, nibbling samosas and sipping tea, had their eyes fixed on Arjun Munda, the Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) veteran and three-term chief minister, about to make the day's final speech at the inauguration meeting of the party's campaign office. One person in the hall, however, seemed focused elsewhere—his wife, Meera Munda, the BJP candidate for Potka constituency. As Munda stood up, Meera leaned in and whispered in Bangla, "*Ami aschi*" (I'll be going). Munda then turned to the audience: "If you permit, we'll let the candidate reach another place." With a bow, Meera exited with Menka Sardar, a former BJP MLA who lost the seat in 2019.

Potka isn't vast by any measure, and it's not that Meera couldn't have waited to hear her husband speak. But in a constituency that has only about 300,000 voters, the 43,110-vote margin by which Jharkhand Mukti Morcha (JMM)'s Sanjib Sardar defeated Menka in the previous election must be weighing heavy on her mind. Sanjib is in the fray again, and the Mundas are acutely aware of the task at hand.

The Mundas are not alone in opting for such a division of labour before Jharkhand votes—in two phases on November 13 and 20—for a new 81-member assembly. Chief Minister Hemant Soren and his wife Kalpana have strategically set up camp in opposite corners of the state. While Kalpana, based in Giridih, tirelessly covers northern seats like Pakur, Dumka and Deoghar, Hemant commands his base from Ranchi. They are mindful of their allies' weaknesses: the Congress lacks a popular figure, and the Rashtriya Janata Dal (RJD) has limited influence in the state. It has fallen on the Sorens, therefore, to connect with voters across Jharkhand's rugged terrain. Kalpana, who came into her own while husband Hemant was in jail, is also the face of the Maiya Samman Yojana Yatra, launched to engage women voters—a linchpin in the Indian National Developmental Inclusive Alliance (INDIA)'s bid for return. And this election will be a test of her ability to emerge as a pan-Jharkhand figure.